POINT OF CHANGE / OPERATIONS

The First Change Has to Prove Something

Before you fund the whole fix, find out which decision would make a difference.



Fran Herrera · Co-founder, Strategy & Operations
Updated November 14, 2026 · 4 min read

A floor-prep crew arrives at a hotel at six. The space is still full of furniture. Dispatch had a start time. The project manager had an email saying the operator needed another day. The job cost report will show four people and a truck with nowhere to work. The owner can approve better scheduling software. What she needs to know first is whether a better schedule could have changed who left the yard.

Choose the first process improvement by finding where a recurring loss becomes avoidable. Compare the outcome each change could affect, what a test would teach, and how much it costs to reverse. Name the person who can act and decide what result would justify investing further.

Where does the first useful change sit?

Follow a recent case to the last practical moment someone could have avoided the loss. Check what they knew and what they were allowed to do. Then check earlier points where that information or authority could have been available.

Donella Meadows distinguishes between changing how information reaches people and changing the rules they can act on. Both are possible places to intervene. In the hotel case, the PM may already know the room is unavailable. A release rule could let them hold the crew. If the hotel itself decides late and the PM has no earlier signal, the first test may be to set a site readiness check with the operator. Donella Meadows, Leverage Points

Think of ordering three things on three different days and getting three boxes. Amazon Day introduced an earlier choice at checkout. Eligible orders could be grouped on a day the customer chose. Amazon reported that its test group used tens of thousands fewer boxes. The announcement gives a total, with no per-order rate or comparable group. What you can borrow is the timing. Amazon put the choice in front of the customer while the orders could still be grouped. Your crew needs the equivalent decision while there's still time to send them to another site. Amazon Day announcement, February 2019

What should the first investment prove?

Write down the decision the pilot will inform. Choose the smallest change that can separate two plausible causes. Track the cost you want to reduce and a second measure that shows whether the change simply moved the problem.

What the company learns from recent mobilizations	First test	What would count as progress
PMs knew access was blocked before crews left and could not hold a start.	Give the PM authority to release one class of starts after confirmation.	Fewer failed mobilizations without an increase in missed commitments.
The operator confirmed access too late for anyone to act.	Agree on a prior-day confirmation time and an escalation contact.	More starts have an actionable access decision before the crew is committed.
The site was ready, but dispatch worked from an older schedule.	Give dispatch one current release view and retire the duplicate list for pilot jobs.	Fewer departures based on a stale start date.

A rule that reduces wasted trips by moving all starts back a day would change the first number and harm the customer. Record planned starts and missed commitments together. For each delayed start, review when the information became available and which decision it allowed.

If several holds free up crew time but the company can't assign that crew anywhere else, the test has found a second constraint. Record how much of the avoided travel and waiting was replaced by productive work. The finance lead can then distinguish a better customer experience, recovered capacity and any cost the company actually avoided.

What goes on a one-page decision record?

Put the business loss, the proposed cause, the smallest test, the decision owner, and the condition for expanding or stopping on one page. Use real cases to define which jobs belong in the comparison.

For the hotel, the test could cover two weeks of floor-prep mobilizations. The PM confirms access with the operator by 3 p.m. on the prior business day and can hold dispatch if access is unconfirmed. Operations records wasted crew hours, changes to promised starts, and the time of each site confirmation. The owner reviews any delayed start that would have succeeded under the old process. A useful result informs whether the next investment is a rule, a different confirmation practice, or software that keeps the release visible.

Three points to bring to the budget discussion.

- Locate the first moment the business can reasonably prevent the loss.
- Test a change that distinguishes between plausible explanations.
- Record the cost of the change and any consequence for the customer.

The next morning at six, the crew will either have an accessible site or be working somewhere the company has assigned it. The test begins the day before, when someone can still choose.

Frequently asked questions

Should we start with the largest cost?

Look at the size of the loss and whether you can influence it. A smaller recurring loss with a clear test may be the better first investment.

What if the pilot gives mixed results?

Review the cases that improved and the ones that got worse. Different conditions may require different rules. Extend or narrow the test if the answer still affects the decision.

When is the pilot ready for a budget decision?

When you can describe which work improved, under what conditions, what it cost, and who will own the change at a larger scale.

The contractor and test are illustrative. Amazon's packaging result is company-reported.